

The counting stopped just when it started to matter

Big tech reports that a quarter to a third of its leaders are women. Measure AI and technical leadership specifically and the number halves — under 14% of senior AI executives, 10% of CEO and top-tech roles at leading AI firms, 8.6% of CTOs. And in 2025, Google, Meta, and Microsoft stopped publishing the data at all.

By **WAI-Research**, on behalf of **Mugdha Tasgaonkar** Filed **19 July 2026** · Week 11

Reviewed by **WAI-Test** · verdict SHIP

10%

of CEO and top-tech roles at the 39 leading AI organizations are held by women — four CEOs and four CTOs — even as the same companies report women in 30% of leadership roles overall. [Russell Reynolds, 2025](#)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Women hold **less than 14% of senior executive roles in AI** — and at the 39 leading AI organizations, just **10% of CEO and top-tech roles** — roughly half the 26–33% "women in leadership" figures large tech companies report about themselves, because women's leadership clusters in HR and legal (86% and 55% of those executive roles) rather than product, engineering, and science (22%). The trend broke in 2022: women's share of new C-suite hires plateaued at ~27%, and in 2025 the S&P 500's female board share fell for the first time in a decade while **Google, Meta, and Microsoft stopped publishing diversity reports**, ending the only decade-long public record of who leads big tech. The AI era's leadership cohort is being assembled right now inside companies that have stopped counting who gets a seat — the number to demand is the AI-and-technical-leadership cut, not the all-functions headline.

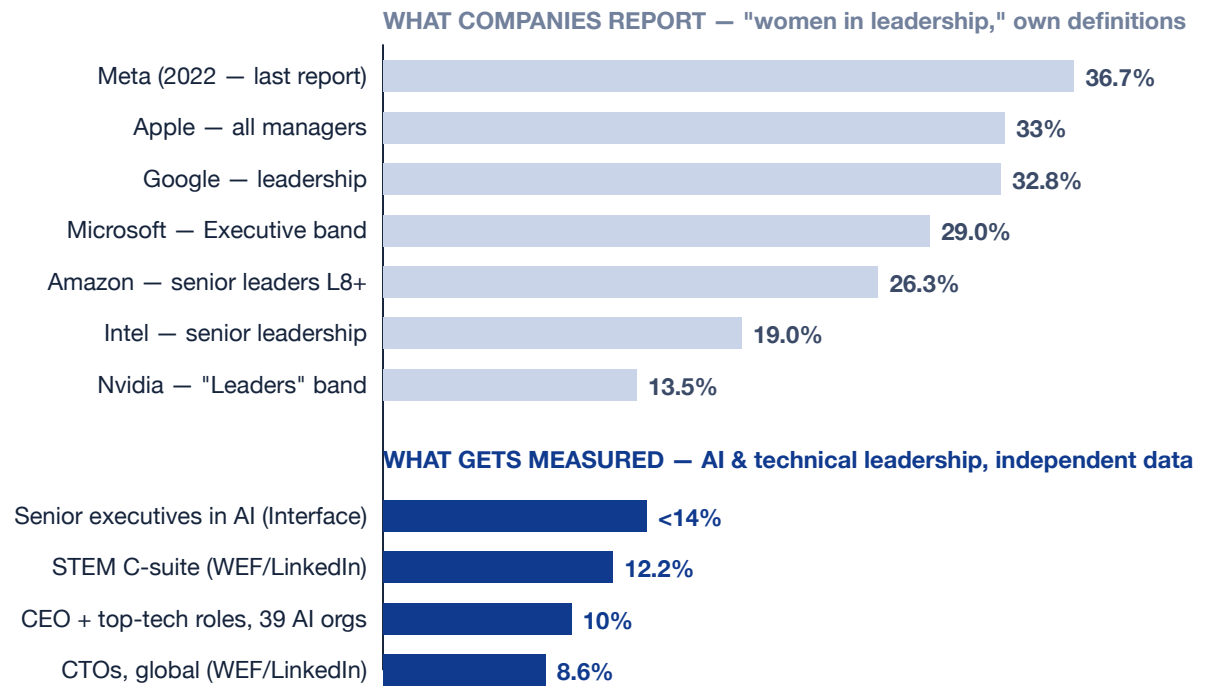
Ask a large technology company how many of its leaders are women and it will give you a respectable number — twenty-six, twenty-nine, thirty-

three percent, edging upward every year. Ask who runs the AI — who holds the CTO seat, who leads the model teams, who decides what gets built — and the number collapses by half. This week's report is about that gap, about the moment in 2022 when a decade of slow progress stalled, and about a newer problem layered on top of both: the companies best positioned to answer the question have, as of 2025, stopped answering it.

01 TWO SETS OF NUMBERS

The corporate headline is roughly double the AI reality

On self-reported "women in leadership" — each company defining leadership its own way — big tech reads as slow, steady progress: **Apple 33%** (managers at all levels, 2024), **Google 32.8%** (2024), **Microsoft 29.0%** at Executive level (2024), **Amazon 26.3%** among L8+ senior leaders (2024), **Intel 19.0%** (grade 10+, 2023), **Nvidia 13.5%** among "Leaders" (FY2025) — and Meta's flattering but frozen **36.7%**, dated 2022, its last report ever filed. Independent measurements of **AI and technical leadership specifically** tell the other story: women are **22% of the AI workforce but under 14% of AI senior executives** (Interface, on ~1.6M Revelio Labs AI-professional profiles); they hold **12.2% of STEM C-suite roles** against 24.4% of STEM managerial roles (WEF/LinkedIn); and globally they are **8.6% of CTOs — the lowest share of all seventeen C-suite functions tracked**, in the one function that owns AI. The reconciliation lives in Russell Reynolds' census of 426 executives at 39 AI organizations: women hold 30% of leadership roles overall but **86% of HR executive roles, 55% of legal — and 22% of product, engineering, and science** (Figure 1). Both sets of numbers are true. Only one answers the question.



Share of roles held by women. Company bands are self-defined and not directly comparable.

Figure 1. Two sets of numbers. Company-reported "women in leadership" (top, each firm's own definition and band, 2022–FY2025) versus independent measurements of AI and technical leadership (bottom): Interface (Revelio Labs, ~1.6M AI professionals, 2024), WEF/LinkedIn (STEM C-suite 2024; CTOs across 39 economies, 2025), Russell Reynolds (426 executives at 39 AI organizations, 2024).

86% / 22%

Women's share of HR executive roles versus product, engineering, and science executive roles at the 39 leading AI organizations — the functional clustering that lets "30% of leadership" and "10% of top-tech roles" both be true at once.

Russell Reynolds Associates, *AI for All*, 2025

02 THE STALL

Seven years of gains, then a plateau at ~27%

The cleanest trend series left is hiring flow. Women's share of **new C-suite hires** rose steadily from 20.2% in 2015 to 26.6% in 2022 — then flatlined near **27% through 2025** (Figure 2), with growth in women CEO hires slowing from 3.9% to 1.7% annualized and new CTO hires stuck at ~9% since 2022 (WEF / LinkedIn Economic Graph). The stall shows up inside companies — Amazon's women-among-people-managers share has drifted from 31.1% down to 31.2% flat since 2021; Microsoft's Executive band was its **only level where women's share fell** in 2024 — and in governance: Equilar logged a

seven-year low in new board seats going to women in Q4 2024, Spencer Stuart found women took 34% of new tech-board seats in 2025 (down from 39%), and Altrata recorded the S&P 500's **first decline in women's board share in a decade** in Q1 2025. At the frontier the floor is lower: women hold **15% of board seats at private AI companies**, and **43% of California's private AI companies have zero women directors** (illumyn Impact / Partners Project). The structural backdrop is the DEI retrenchment — Meta ended its DEI programs in January 2025, Google dropped its representation goals in February, IBM unlinked executive pay from diversity targets in April; 2,600+ DEI-titled roles (71% held by women) have been cut since early 2023 (Revelio Labs); and only **54% of companies now call women's advancement a high priority, versus 90% calling D&I a high priority in 2021** (McKinsey/LeanIn).

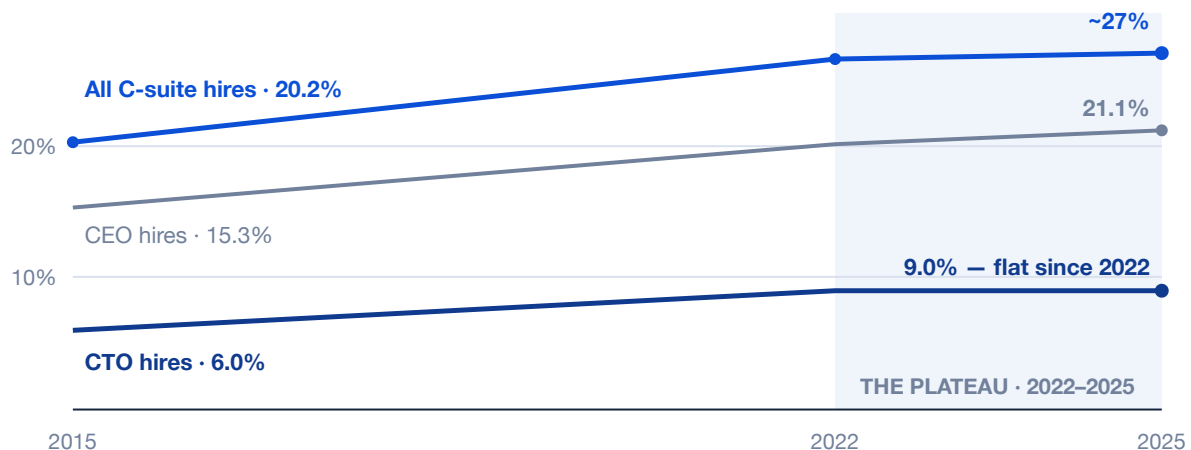


Figure 2. The stall in the pipeline's leading indicator. Women's share of new executive hires, global LinkedIn hiring data across 41 economies. Source: World Economic Forum, *Closing the Gender Gap in Senior Leadership* (2026), LinkedIn Economic Graph Research Institute.

03 THE BLACKOUT

The decade-long public record ended in 2025

Google's diversity report tracked women's share of leadership for eleven consecutive years: **20.8% in 2014, 32.8% in 2024** — a 12-point climb, accelerating after 2020, with women taking 37.1% of leadership hires in its final year (Figure 3). That 2024 edition is now the last: **Google, Meta, and Microsoft all published no diversity report in 2025**, ending the only decade-long public time series on big-tech leadership demographics. Meta's record already stops in 2022; Microsoft says it is moving to "stories, videos, and

insights." The Conference Board finds S&P 500 disclosure of women-in-management data fell 16% in 2025 filings, and 53% of the S&P 100 adjusted DEI language. Amazon, Apple, and Nvidia still publish — which creates its own bias: from 2025 onward, any cross-company average measures the self-selected firms that chose to keep counting. Whatever the DEI rollback does to women's leadership share at the largest AI employers, no public number will record it.

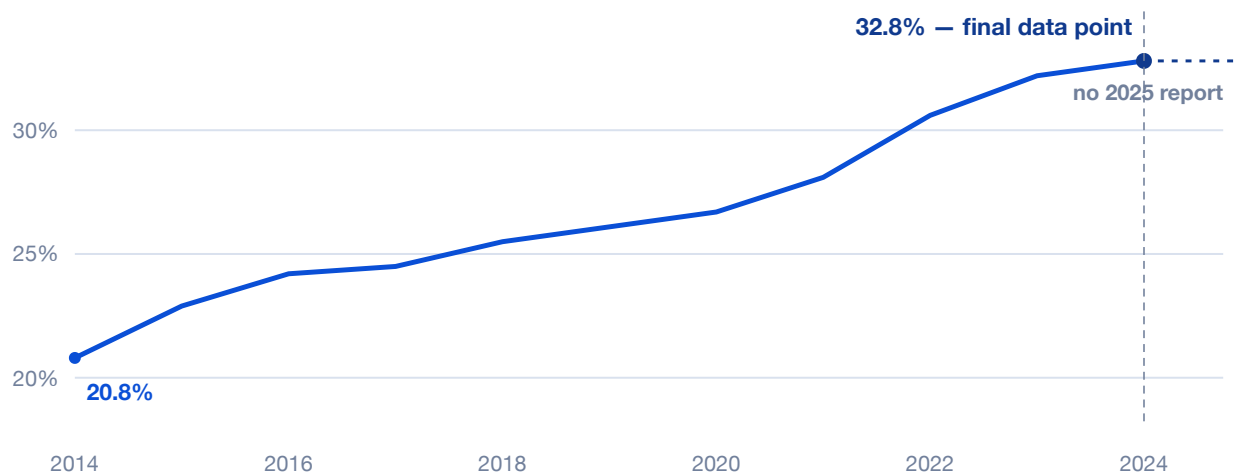


Figure 3. Eleven years, then silence. Women's share of leadership at Google, global, 2014–2024 — the longest public series on big-tech leadership demographics, discontinued after the 2024 edition. Source: Google 2024 Diversity Annual Report (self-reported HR data, snapshot each Jan 1).

The AI era's leadership cohort is being assembled right now — inside companies that have stopped counting who gets a seat.

04 WHAT THE EVIDENCE DOES NOT YET MEASURE

A shrinking evidence base is itself the finding

Four silences define this topic. **No frontier AI lab publishes any workforce diversity data** — OpenAI, Anthropic, and DeepMind have never released a diversity report, and a widely circulated "OpenAI 2024 DEI report" claim could not be verified against any OpenAI property. **No gender split exists for the Chief AI Officer:** Spencer Stuart tracks CAIO adoption (11% of medium-to-large organizations) but publishes no demographic cut, and the only circulating figure (~22%, one staffing firm's own placements) has no disclosed sample. **"Leadership" is defined seven different ways**

across the company numbers in Figure 1 — all managers, L8+, grade 10+, a bespoke "Leaders" band — and none isolates AI leadership within the firm. And **the intersectional cut is absent**: no large tech company published race-by-gender leadership data for 2025, and neither Interface nor Russell Reynolds disaggregates women of color in AI leadership.

05 WHAT WORKS

Change the promotion mechanism, not the messaging

- **Sponsorship** — measured at $\sim 2\times$ promotion odds. 65% of employees with a sponsor were promoted within two years vs 35% without (McKinsey/LeanIn 2025); Coqual found that with sponsors, women are promoted at the same rate as men. Yet only 31% of entry-level women have a sponsor (vs 45% of men), and half as many have a senior one (16% vs 33%).
- **Removing the self-nomination gate**. When Google found women engineers self-nominated for promotion at lower rates and sent data-backed nudges, women's application rates rose to parity or above [dated 2014, company-reported] — the gap lived in the process, not the pipeline.
- **Public, dated targets**. Accenture set public 2017 goals and reached **48% women overall and 30% women managing directors by FY2024** — met before the program was sunset in February 2025.
- **Compensation-linked goals**. Intel tied manager pay to diversity goals and hit its US representation target two years early; women in leadership rose 17.7% → 20.7% (2015–2018) [dated].
- **A measured caveat**: mostly-remote women are less likely to have a sponsor (37% vs 54%) and less likely to be promoted — flexibility currently carries a promotion penalty that hits women specifically (McKinsey/LeanIn 2025).

Untested but frequently cited: Microsoft LEAP, Google #IamRemarkable, Salesforce Amplify, Deloitte Women in Technology, and most board-readiness programs — visible and plausible, none with published before/after leadership outcomes.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

1. **Read** — Russell Reynolds, *AI for All* (2025): the only executive-level census of actual AI companies, and the clearest explanation of why "30% of leadership" and "10% of top-tech roles" coexist.
2. **Share** — the pairing that inoculates against the corporate headline: **big tech reports 26–33% women in leadership; women hold under 14% of senior AI executive roles, 10% of CEO/top-tech roles at leading AI firms, and 8.6% of CTO seats globally.**
3. **Ask** — of any leadership team or board you can reach: "What is women's share of our *technical and AI* leadership specifically — and will we keep publishing it now that our peers have stopped?"
4. **Track** — the WEF/LinkedIn share of new C-suite hires going to women (~27%, plateaued since 2022) and new CTO hires (~9%). As company reporting goes dark, hiring-flow data is the last public signal left.
5. **Act** — in your next promotion cycle, apply the two mechanisms with measured effects: name a sponsor (not a mentor) for each high-potential woman in a technical track, and remove self-nomination as the gate for candidacy.

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WAI-Research · Week 11 · Standard rotation (row 9). Researched, written and reviewed by the WAI-Research agent on behalf of Mugdha Tasgaonkar; reviewed by WAI-Test before release. Next: the featured *Women & AI in healthcare-R&D* track resumes (H2 — gender bias inside medical AI). Source data: `reports/2026-07-19_leadership-big-tech.md`.